

A Project Is Not Ready Because a Plan Exists

Four operating commitments before work earns a start

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EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Work should not start until decision rights, outcome boundaries, stakeholder participation, and named capacity are explicit.

Readiness is not the presence of a populated plan. It is an earned decision that the organization can sustain the next commitment without hiding unresolved sponsorship, scope, participation, or capacity inside the delivery team. This paper gives sponsors, portfolio leaders, PMO leaders, and delivery executives a practical the four-commitment readiness test for making the next commitment explicit.

- 01** The sponsor can decide: The sponsor must have authority over the choices the work is likely to force; visibility into status is insufficient.
- 02** Outcome and boundary are explicit: A team needs one operational outcome and a visible boundary around what this tranche will not attempt.
- 03** Stakeholders will participate: Stakeholder support becomes readiness only when the work has access to the people, decisions, data, and adoption effort it depends on.
- 04** Named capacity and capability exist: A staffing plan is credible only when the scarce roles are named, available, and capable of doing the work at the required time.

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The argument

Readiness is not the presence of a populated plan. It is an earned decision that the organization can sustain the next commitment without hiding unresolved sponsorship, scope, participation, or capacity inside the delivery team.

I have seen projects arrive at kickoff with a credible schedule, a polished charter, and a room full of supportive leaders, yet still be unready to start. The missing pieces were rarely another planning field. They were operating commitments: who would make a hard decision, what outcome was actually protected, which business people would participate, and whether named delivery capacity existed after the meeting ended.

A kickoff date can create its own momentum. Once invitations are sent and a team is announced, asking whether the work should start feels like delay. That social pressure is precisely why readiness needs a decision standard before the calendar takes over.

This paper is written for sponsors, portfolio leaders, PMO leaders, and delivery executives. It offers the four-commitment readiness test as a management instrument: a way to connect operating evidence to the next consequential choice. The cited sources provide external context; the framework and its application are Marco Policani's synthesis. It is not a predictive score and does not replace professional, legal, security, financial, or domain judgment.

Why the conventional approach breaks

The control belongs at the point where reliance expands, not in a retrospective explanation after the outcome is known. Conventional governance tends to separate planning, approval, delivery reporting, and operating ownership. That separation allows a premise to pass through several forums without any one forum owning the decision it implies. The project or workflow then carries an assumption that was acknowledged socially but never accepted operationally.

A local fix can keep the work moving while worsening the portfolio: another specialist is borrowed, another exception is tolerated, and another dependency is promised twice. The answer is not heavier control at every step. It is to place a clear, proportionate test at the point where the organization increases money, capacity, access, dependency, or action authority.

The four-commitment readiness test

The model has 4 connected elements. Each makes a different condition visible, but they should be reviewed together because strength in one area does not cancel a missing obligation in another. The model is designed for a short executive conversation supported by inspectable evidence, not a long maturity assessment.

EXHIBIT 1

The four-commitment readiness test connects evidence to action

- 1 **The sponsor can decide**
The sponsor must have authority over the choices the work is likely to force; visibility into status is insufficient.
- 2 **Outcome and boundary are explicit**
A team needs one operational outcome and a visible boundary around what this tranche will not attempt.
- 3 **Stakeholders will participate**
Stakeholder support becomes readiness only when the work has access to the people, decisions, data, and adoption effort it depends on.
- 4 **Named capacity and capability exist**
A staffing plan is credible only when the scarce roles are named, available, and capable of doing the work at the required time.

The sponsor can decide

The sponsor must have authority over the choices the work is likely to force; visibility into status is insufficient. The distinction matters because leaders authorize commitments, while teams inherit whatever the authorization left unresolved.

A nominal sponsor attends updates but cannot settle scope, policy, funding, or cross-functional conflict; the team then shops decisions through an informal network. What looks like a team-level miss is frequently a portfolio choice that nobody made explicitly. Scarce attention is then spent reconciling consequences rather than choosing among alternatives.

List the first consequential decisions, confirm who can make each one, and name the escalation route when authority sits elsewhere. A named owner must be able to change the work; receiving a notification after the boundary is crossed is insufficient.

A short decision-rights record, acceptance of the escalation route, and evidence that the sponsor has protected time for the first gate. The evidence owner is accountable for integrity, while the decision owner remains accountable for the commitment. Keeping those roles distinct improves challenge.

Start, narrow, or hold the work based on whether decision authority matches the commitment being made. The residual uncertainty belongs in the decision record so later outcomes are compared with what leaders actually knew at the time.

A tabletop review of the sponsor can decide should use the observed break as its scenario: A nominal sponsor attends updates but cannot settle scope, policy, funding, or cross-functional conflict; the team then shops decisions through an informal network. Participants then apply the proposed response. They list the first consequential decisions, confirm who can make each one, and name the escalation route when authority sits elsewhere. The review identifies where authority, information, time, or recovery would run out. It is useful only if it changes the boundary or confirms who will act when the condition appears.

The minimum record for the sponsor can decide is anchored in actual proof. It includes a short decision-rights record, acceptance of the escalation route, and evidence that the sponsor has protected time for the first gate. The record also carries the choice supported by that proof: Start, narrow, or hold the work based on whether decision authority matches the commitment being made. Keeping evidence and decision together lets a later owner distinguish a deliberate residual risk from a premise that nobody examined. It also gives the team a clear reason to reopen the choice when the underlying facts change.

Across the work governed by sponsors, portfolio leaders, PMO leaders, and delivery executives, occurrences of this pattern should be compared rather than treated as unrelated project stories. The positive standard is: The sponsor must have authority over the choices the work is likely to force; visibility into status is insufficient. If the same failure recurs, leaders can change delegation, capacity, intake, policy, or the intervention itself. That portfolio response is usually more valuable than asking each team to absorb another local workaround.

Two questions test the sponsor can decide. What evidence would show that the condition is no longer adequate? Would that evidence arrive early enough to preserve a feasible choice? The intended choice is clear: Start, narrow, or hold the work based on whether decision authority matches the commitment being made. A weak answer to either question calls for a smaller commitment, an earlier signal, or a safer fallback. A strong answer earns movement without claiming that uncertainty has disappeared.

Outcome and boundary are explicit

A team needs one operational outcome and a visible boundary around what this tranche will not attempt. The control belongs at the point where reliance expands, not in a retrospective explanation after the outcome is known.

Success is expressed as delivery of outputs, while benefits, exclusions, and acceptable tradeoffs remain open to interpretation. Momentum makes the weakness self-reinforcing. Each additional commitment raises the political and economic cost of revisiting the premise.

Write the outcome as a change in operating condition, identify the baseline, and make exclusions and non-goals as visible as the deliverables. The record should travel with the work so that later participants can see the basis for reliance instead of reconstructing it from memory.

An outcome statement that the process owner accepts, a baseline or credible proxy, and recorded boundaries for scope and consequence. The strongest record shows both what supports the choice and what could overturn it.

Approve the next tranche only when leaders can explain what result would justify continuing and what result would cause redesign. Decision quality improves when dissent and competing evidence are preserved instead of flattened into a unanimous-looking status.

A tabletop review of outcome and boundary are explicit should use the observed break as its scenario: Success is expressed as delivery of outputs, while benefits, exclusions, and acceptable tradeoffs remain open to interpretation. Participants then apply the proposed response. They write the outcome as a change in operating condition, identify the baseline, and make exclusions and non-goals as visible as the deliverables. The review identifies where authority, information, time, or recovery would run out. It is useful only if it changes the boundary or confirms who will act when the condition appears.

The minimum record for outcome and boundary are explicit is anchored in actual proof. It includes an outcome statement that the process owner accepts, a baseline or credible proxy, and recorded boundaries for scope and consequence. The record also carries the choice supported by that proof: Approve the next tranche only when leaders can explain what result would justify continuing and what result would cause redesign. Keeping evidence and decision together lets a later owner distinguish a deliberate residual risk from a premise that nobody examined. It also gives the team a clear reason to reopen the choice when the underlying facts change.

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Stakeholders will participate

Stakeholder support becomes readiness only when the work has access to the people, decisions, data, and adoption effort it depends on. This is where a management ritual either becomes a real control or reveals itself as administrative theater.

Names appear on a stakeholder map, but operational experts are unavailable for design, testing, acceptance, or the behavior change after launch. Because responsibility is distributed, no single event appears large enough to stop the work. The accumulated operating load is the real exposure.

Convert stakeholder labels into dated participation commitments tied to concrete work: workshops, decisions, data validation, testing, and transition ownership. Evidence should be selected for decision value. Volume is not rigor when the decisive uncertainty remains untested.

Named participants, time commitments acknowledged by their managers, and a fallback when an essential contributor is pulled away. A later outcome should feed back into the evidence standard so repeated surprises improve the next commitment.

Reduce scope, move the date, or stop pretending the dependency is covered when participation cannot be secured. A decision without consequence invites the old behavior to continue. Capacity, funding, permissions, scope, or sequence must move with the answer.

A tabletop review of stakeholders will participate should use the observed break as its scenario: Names appear on a stakeholder map, but operational experts are unavailable for design, testing, acceptance, or the behavior change after launch. Participants then apply the proposed response. They convert stakeholder labels into dated participation commitments tied to concrete work: workshops, decisions, data validation, testing, and transition ownership. The review identifies where authority, information, time, or recovery would run out. It is useful only if it changes the boundary or confirms who will act when the condition appears.

The minimum record for stakeholders will participate is anchored in actual proof. It includes named participants, time commitments acknowledged by their managers, and a fallback when an essential contributor is pulled away. The record also carries the choice supported by that proof: Reduce scope, move the date, or stop pretending the dependency is covered when participation cannot be secured. Keeping evidence and decision together lets a later owner distinguish a deliberate residual risk from a premise that nobody examined. It also gives the team a clear reason to reopen the choice when the underlying facts change.

Across the work governed by sponsors, portfolio leaders, PMO leaders, and delivery executives, occurrences of this pattern should be compared rather than treated as unrelated project stories. The positive standard is: Stakeholder support becomes readiness only when the work has access to the people, decisions, data, and adoption effort it depends on. If the same failure recurs, leaders can change delegation, capacity, intake, policy, or the intervention itself. That portfolio response is usually more valuable than asking each team to absorb another local workaround.

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Named capacity and capability exist

A staffing plan is credible only when the scarce roles are named, available, and capable of doing the work at the required time. The work becomes governable when ownership, evidence, boundaries, and response are connected to a real choice.

The plan counts generic full-time equivalents while the same architect, product owner, analyst, or subject expert is promised to several initiatives. When the consequence finally becomes visible, leaders face a narrower choice set and a more expensive recovery.

Plan capacity by constrained role and decision load; test the commitment against other active work and the expected peaks rather than an annual average. The control should be short enough to use at the decision point and specific enough that a skeptical owner can challenge it.

Role-level allocations, competing commitments, onboarding needs, and a capacity owner who can resolve collisions before they reach delivery. Ranges and contradictory observations are often more useful than a precise point estimate built on weak assumptions.

Sequence, reshape, or wait when the portfolio cannot supply the scarce capability without damaging work already in flight. The decision should identify the sacrifice. If every priority remains protected, the tradeoff has been delegated rather than resolved.

A tabletop review of named capacity and capability exist should use the observed break as its scenario: The plan counts generic full-time equivalents while the same architect, product owner, analyst, or subject expert is promised to several initiatives. Participants then apply the proposed response. They plan capacity by constrained role and decision load; test the commitment against other active work and the expected peaks rather than an annual average. The review identifies where authority, information, time, or recovery would run out. It is useful only if it changes the boundary or confirms who will act when the condition appears.

The minimum record for named capacity and capability exist is anchored in actual proof. It includes role-level allocations, competing commitments, onboarding needs, and a capacity owner who can resolve collisions before they reach delivery. The record also carries the choice supported by that proof: Sequence, reshape, or wait when the portfolio cannot supply the scarce capability without damaging work already in flight. Keeping evidence and decision together lets a later owner distinguish a deliberate residual risk from a premise that nobody examined. It also gives the team a clear reason to reopen the choice when the underlying facts change.

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Two questions test named capacity and capability exist. What evidence would show that the condition is no longer adequate? Would that evidence arrive early enough to preserve a feasible choice? The intended choice is clear: Sequence, reshape, or wait when the portfolio cannot supply the scarce capability without damaging work already in flight. A weak answer to either question calls for a smaller commitment, an earlier signal, or a safer fallback. A strong answer earns movement without claiming that uncertainty has disappeared.

How the elements interact

The sponsor can decide and Outcome and boundary are explicit protect different parts of the same commitment. The sponsor must have authority over the choices the work is likely to force; visibility into status is insufficient. A team needs one operational outcome and a visible boundary around what this tranche will not attempt. A useful governance design therefore begins with the consequence leaders are prepared to accept. If the operation encounters this failure—a nominal sponsor attends updates but cannot settle scope, policy, funding, or cross-functional conflict; the team then shops decisions through an informal network.—the response for outcome and boundary are explicit cannot compensate for the missing the sponsor can decide obligation. Reviewers should reconcile the evidence for both elements before they accept the next action: approve the next tranche only when leaders can explain what result would justify continuing and what result would cause redesign.

Outcome and boundary are explicit and Stakeholders will participate protect different parts of the same commitment. A team needs one operational outcome and a visible boundary around what this tranche will not attempt. Stakeholder support becomes readiness only when the work has access to the people, decisions, data, and adoption effort it depends on. This is where a management ritual either becomes a real control or reveals itself as administrative theater. If the operation encounters this failure—success is expressed as delivery of outputs, while benefits, exclusions, and acceptable tradeoffs remain open to interpretation.—the response for stakeholders will participate cannot compensate for the missing outcome and boundary are explicit obligation. Reviewers should reconcile the evidence for both elements before they accept the next action: reduce scope, move the date, or stop pretending the dependency is covered when participation cannot be secured.

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Named capacity and capability exist and The sponsor can decide protect different parts of the same commitment. A staffing plan is credible only when the scarce roles are named, available, and capable of doing the work at the required time. The sponsor must have authority over the choices the work is likely to force; visibility into status is insufficient. A strong operating model makes the hidden negotiation explicit while options are still available. If the operation encounters this failure—the plan counts generic full-time equivalents while the same architect, product owner, analyst, or subject expert is promised to several initiatives.—the response for the sponsor can decide cannot compensate for the missing named capacity and capability exist obligation. Reviewers should reconcile the evidence for both elements before they accept the next action: start, narrow, or hold the work based on whether decision authority matches the commitment being made.

Put the model into the management cadence

A framework becomes useful when it changes the normal cadence of work. It should shape intake, funding, design, delivery, and operating review without creating a separate governance industry around itself. The following sequence is deliberately small:

EXHIBIT 2

Start with one decision, then calibrate from evidence

- 1 **Move 1**
Use the test before a kickoff is scheduled, not inside the kickoff deck.
- 2 **Move 2**
Record one decision for the next commitment: approve, approve with a boundary, stage discovery, narrow, or hold.
- 3 **Move 3**
Re-test readiness when a material dependency, sponsor, outcome, or capacity assumption changes.
- 4 **Move 4**
Review false starts quarterly and change the intake questions that allowed them through.

- Use the test before a kickoff is scheduled, not inside the kickoff deck.
- Record one decision for the next commitment: approve, approve with a boundary, stage discovery, narrow, or hold.
- Re-test readiness when a material dependency, sponsor, outcome, or capacity assumption changes.
- Review false starts quarterly and change the intake questions that allowed them through.

The first cycle should be treated as calibration. Reviewers should note which questions changed a decision, which evidence was unavailable, where authority was unclear, and which controls cost out of proportion to the exposure. That record improves the four-commitment readiness test without pretending the first version will fit every workflow or investment.

Ownership should remain close to the consequence. The PMO or AI-governance function can maintain the method, surface cross-portfolio patterns, and challenge weak evidence. It should not absorb the business owner's accountability for the result or the executive's accountability for the commitment.

Measures that reveal whether the control works

- Time from a material signal to a consequential decision.
- Commitments narrowed, redirected, paused, or stopped before avoidable exposure grew.
- Exceptions or assumptions discovered after the latest useful decision date.
- Scarce specialist and executive attention consumed by recurring unresolved conditions.

- Decisions reopened because the original evidence, boundary, or rationale was unclear.
- Operating outcomes and recovery performance after reliance expanded.

These measures are diagnostic, not a universal scorecard. Their purpose is to identify where the operating model fails repeatedly and whether governance is preserving options earlier. A lower count can indicate improvement, but it can also indicate weak detection. Leaders should read the measures with case evidence and frontline observation.

The strongest counterargument

The test is not a universal score and it cannot eliminate uncertainty. A small reversible discovery effort needs less proof than a large, dependent, difficult-to-reverse commitment. The discipline is proportionality: require enough evidence for the consequence of the next step.

A reasonable critic could also argue that experienced leaders already do this through judgment. Many do. The weakness is not the absence of judgment; it is the absence of a durable operating record when people, pressure, and conditions change. The four-commitment readiness test makes the basis for judgment visible enough to challenge, execute, and revisit.

The shift

Readiness is not the presence of a populated plan. It is an earned decision that the organization can sustain the next commitment without hiding unresolved sponsorship, scope, participation, or capacity inside the delivery team. The practical shift is from reporting activity to governing the conditions under which the organization relies on that activity.

That discipline does not make uncertainty disappear. It gives leaders a better place to stand: a named decision, evidence proportionate to consequence, an explicit boundary, a responsible owner, and a response when reality departs from the assumption. Those elements are enough to turn hidden operating risk into a choice the portfolio can make deliberately.

Notes and sources

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About the author

Marco Policani is an enterprise portfolio, PMO, and AI operating-governance leader. He builds portfolio governance systems where AI carries the analytical load and named humans own every decision — an approach documented across case studies, walkthroughs, and working governance guides on his portfolio site.

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